SABER: Support-Conditioned Adaptive Bellman Error Reweighting for Sparse HER Actor-Critic

Anonymous submission

Content Areas:
ML: Reinforcement, Imitation & Inverse RL (primary);
ROB: Robot Learning, Control & Foundation Models (secondary)

Abstract

Hindsight Experience Replay (HER) converts failed experience into goal-conditioned training data through achieved-goal relabeling. Most HER extensions alter goal selection, replay selection, or target construction. We instead ask whether per-sample squared Bellman residuals should remain equally weighted once relabeling and replay sampling are fixed. We introduce SABER (Support-Conditioned Adaptive Bellman Error Reweighting), a critic-only objective. SABER upweights a sample's squared Bellman residual when a sufficiently populated local replay set from the same discretized state–goal–horizon context contains an action in the current-policy action bin. It normalizes the weights to unit minibatch mean and uses the current-policy action only for the support query while retaining Bellman regression at the replay action. HER relabeling, uniform replay sampling, the actor objective, Bellman targets, network architectures, and the update-to-data (UTD) ratio remain unchanged. Under matched UTD-1 training on FetchPickAndPlace, SABER raises mean normalized success AUC from 0.539 to 0.609 with DDPG, from 0.372 to 0.442 with TD3, and from 0.471 to 0.583 with SAC. Paired-bootstrap 95% confidence intervals for the AUC differences exclude zero for TD3 and SAC but include zero for DDPG. On DrawerOpen with DDPG, SABER raises mean AUC from 0.207 to 0.754 and mean final success from 0.390 to 1.000. Controlled comparisons, ablations, and diagnostics examine alternative allocation mechanisms and characterize SABER's support signal. These gains, achieved under the same one-update budget and an otherwise unchanged HER pipeline, establish post-HER critic-loss allocation as a distinct design axis capable of substantial performance improvements.

1 Introduction

A central challenge in sparse-reward goal-conditioned reinforcement learning is obtaining useful supervision when successful trajectories are rare. Hindsight Experience Replay (HER) addresses this challenge by relabeling failed experience with achieved goals (Andrychowicz et al. 2017). Once

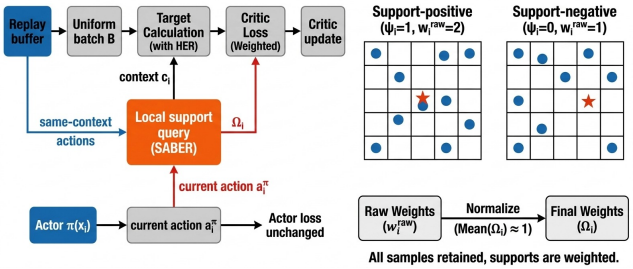


Figure 1: SABER intervenes after HER relabeling and before critic-loss aggregation. Stage 3 uses the current-policy action only to query local support; Stage 4 keeps Bellman regression at the replay action.

sampling and relabeling are fixed, however, standard HER actor–critics assign equal coefficients to all sampled Bellman residuals. This leaves a separate question: should critic supervision remain uniform when the critic regresses at replay actions but the actor queries the critic at current-policy actions?

We introduce SABER (Support-Conditioned Adaptive Bellman Error Reweighting), a critic-only post-HER objective. SABER tests whether replay actions from the same discretized state–goal–horizon context occupy the current-policy action bin, upweights support-positive residuals, and normalizes weights to unit minibatch mean. The current-policy action is used only for this support query; regression remains at the replay action. Relabeling, replay sampling, rewards, Bellman targets, actor optimization, architectures, and the update budget remain unchanged.

Our contributions are: (i) identifying post-HER critic-loss allocation as distinct from goal selection, replay prioritization, and target construction; (ii) introducing a normalized local-support objective that preserves the underlying HER actor–critic pipeline; and (iii) evaluating its cross-backbone repeatability, query and count-matched controls, update-budget trade-offs, diagnostics, and task-dependent success and failure boundaries.

2 Related Work

Goal-conditioned methods modify several stages around HER. HGG and CHER generate or schedule hindsight goals,

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EBP prioritizes energetic episodes, and HGR prioritizes both episodes and transition–future-goal pairs by TD error with two-stage importance correction (Ren et al. 2019; Fang et al. 2019; Zhao and Tresp 2018; Luu and Yoo 2021). MHER changes relabeled returns, ARCHER rescales hindsight rewards, and USHER corrects hindsight-induced value bias (Yang et al. 2021; Lanka and Wu 2018; Schramm et al. 2023). These methods change goal construction, experience selection, rewards, or targets. In contrast, SABER intervenes only after goal construction, replay sampling, rewards, and Bellman targets have been fixed: it preserves the relabeled minibatch and changes only the coefficient assigned to each critic Bellman residual.

General replay methods redistribute experience independently of HER. PER samples by TD error with importance correction, AER selects state-similar transitions, and ReF-ER suppresses far-policy samples while regularizing the actor (Schaul et al. 2015; **?**; Novati and Koumoutsakos 2019). SABER instead preserves minibatch membership and uses conditional action support only to set critic-loss coefficients.

Closer critic-reweighting methods learn different signals: likelihood-free importance weighting estimates a policy-to-replay density ratio, DisCor estimates target accuracy, and ReenGAGE adds goal-gradient distillation (**???**). SABER learns neither a density ratio nor an error model and adds no auxiliary target. Its distinction is a non-learned, sample-aligned current-policy action-support predicate applied to post-HER critic residuals.

3 SABER

3.1 Problem Setting and Post-HER Critic-Loss Allocation

We consider a finite-horizon goal-conditioned MDP $\mathcal{M} = (\mathcal{S}, \mathcal{A}, \mathcal{G}, P, r, \gamma, H)$, with goal-conditioned input $x = (o, g)$, policy $\pi_\theta(a \mid x)$, and critic $Q_{\phi_k}(x, a)$. Rewards are sparse: zero on goal achievement and -1 otherwise. Future-goal HER relabels a sampled transition with $\tilde{g}_i = m(s_{t'})$, $t' > t$, recomputes $\tilde{r}_i$, and produces $x_i = (o_i, \tilde{g}_i)$. DDPG, TD3, and SAC retain their standard backbone-specific targets y_i^{A}, bootstrap masks, and actor objectives (Lillicrap et al. 2015; Fujimoto, van Hoof, and Meger 2018; Haarnoja et al. 2018).

For a uniformly sampled, relabeled minibatch B, let

$$\delta_{ik} = Q_{\phi_k}(x_i, a_i^r) - y_i^{\mathsf{A}}, \qquad \mathcal{L}_Q^{\mathrm{HER}} = \frac{1}{|B|} \sum_{i \in B} \sum_{k=1}^{n_Q} \delta_{ik}^2, \tag{1}$$

where a_i^r is the replay action, $n_Q = 1$ for DDPG, and $n_Q = 2$ for TD3 and SAC. Standard HER therefore gives every sampled residual the same coefficient. SABER asks whether local replay evidence for the current-policy action a_i^π can instead allocate critic-loss weight while leaving the relabeled batch and y_i^{A} fixed.

3.2 Current-Policy Local Support

For sample i, SABER builds a task-specific discrete context $c_i = C(o_i, \tilde{g}_i, h_i)$, where h_i is the remaining horizon. A bounded replay index retrieves at most N_{scan} same-coarse-context candidates and filters them by the full context, yielding the local index set I_i. The relabeled query goal $\tilde{g}_i$ is used for both query and candidate contexts. Exact context features and indexing details are provided in the supplementary artifact.

Let $b_K(a)$ denote the multidimensional bin obtained by normalizing each action dimension to its environment bounds and dividing it into K bins, and let $\mathcal{U}_i = \{b_K(a_j^r) : j \in I_i\}$. With $n_i = |I_i|$, SABER defines

$$\psi_i = \mathbf{1}\{n_i \geq N_{\mathrm{local}}\}\, \mathbf{1}\{\min(n_i, M_{\mathrm{cap}}) \geq M_{\mathrm{avail}}\} \cdot \mathbf{1}\{b_K(a_i^\pi) \in \mathcal{U}_i\}\,. \tag{2}$$

The main setting uses $K = 5$, $N_{\mathrm{scan}} = 512$, $N_{\mathrm{local}} = 4$, $M_{\mathrm{cap}} = 16$, and $M_{\mathrm{avail}} = 4$. DDPG and TD3 use their deterministic actor action as a_i^π, while SAC uses its deterministic squashed mean. The indicator uses neither Q-values nor TD errors: the current-policy action is used only for the discrete support query, and Bellman regression remains at a_i^r.

3.3 Normalized Critic-Only Objective

SABER assigns and normalizes per-sample weights as

$$w_i^{\mathrm{raw}} = 1 + \lambda_S \psi_i, \qquad \bar{w}_B = \frac{1}{|B|} \sum_{j \in B} w_j^{\mathrm{raw}}, \tag{3}$$

$$\Omega_i = \frac{w_i^{\mathrm{raw}}}{\max(\epsilon_w, \bar{w}_B)}. \tag{4}$$

The main method uses $\lambda_S = 1$, giving raw weights two and one to support-positive and support-negative samples. Its critic objective is

$$\mathcal{L}_Q^{\mathrm{SABER}} = \frac{1}{|B|} \sum_{i \in B} \Omega_i \sum_{k=1}^{n_Q} \delta_{ik}^2. \tag{5}$$

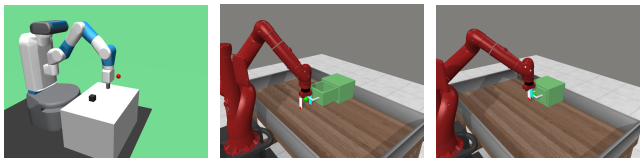
For TD3 and SAC, the same Ω_i weights both critic residuals. All coefficients remain positive and have minibatch mean one, so SABER preserves minibatch membership and approximately preserves the per-update loss scale while changing the relative residual contributions.

The main variant leaves the backbone actor objective unchanged. This preserves the DDPG, TD3, and SAC policy-update rules and isolates Bellman-loss allocation; critic-only is attribution-focused rather than claimed to be performance-optimal. Overall, SABER leaves HER, replay sampling, Bellman targets, architectures, optimizers, exploration, and UTD unchanged. Support is a binary occupancy proxy, not an estimate of density, uncertainty, or target accuracy, and SABER does not directly regress at the current-policy action or generate actions absent from replay.

4 Experiments

4.1 Common Experimental Protocol

Tasks, cohorts, and training protocol. We evaluate FetchPickAndPlace-v4 (FPP; horizon 50, 1M environment steps) with DDPG, TD3, and SAC, and Meta-World



(a) FetchPickAndPlace (b) DrawerOpen (c) DrawerClose

Figure 2: Illustrative simulator renderings of the experimental tasks. The panels are not evaluation rollouts.

DrawerOpen and DrawerClose (horizon 200, 2M steps) with DDPG and TD3. Primary comparisons use paired seeds 1–5, future-goal HER probability 0.8, and UTD 1. We make no paired claims for SAC on the Drawer tasks because no complete matched HER–SABER cohort exists: the available DrawerOpen SAC+HER runs remain at zero success for all five seeds, and neither matched SABER runs nor DrawerClose SAC results were collected. Sparse rewards and future relabeling follow HER (Andrychowicz et al. 2017); backbone targets and policy updates follow DDPG, TD3, and SAC (Lillicrap et al. 2015; Fujimoto, van Hoof, and Meger 2018; Haarnoja et al. 2018). Shared continuous-control settings are fixed within each matched task–backbone cohort without method-specific retuning; complete values, implementation details, and provenance are provided in the supplement.

Evaluation and statistics. Policies are evaluated deterministically over 20 episodes at each checkpoint. Paired analyses use only exact shared evaluation steps, without smoothing, interpolation, or filling. Normalized success AUC is the trapezoidal area divided by the shared step span; final success and Hit90 (the first checkpoint with success ≥ 0.9, reported with reached-seed coverage) are secondary. We report seed means and sample standard deviations; paired claims use within-seed differences and 10,000-resample percentile-bootstrap 95% confidence intervals. Absolute AUC values are not compared across tasks with different horizons or budgets.

4.2 Primary Comparisons

Comparison setup. HER addresses sparse supervision through goal relabeling, but learning effort can be reallocated at several stages of the resulting training pipeline. We compare methods that intervene at three distinct points. HGR changes hindsight-experience selection by prioritizing episodes and transition–future-goal pairs according to TD error, with importance correction at both stages (Luu and Yoo 2021). PER changes replay selection by sampling replay transitions according to TD-error priorities and applying annealed importance correction (Schaul et al. 2015). SABER instead preserves both selections and changes only the critic-loss coefficients within the sampled and relabeled minibatch. These methods are therefore alternative interventions within the HER actor–critic pipeline rather than variants of a single mechanism.

We additionally include *TD-error critic-loss weighting* as a direct allocation control. It retains uniform replay and the sampled HER minibatch, computes detached TD-error priorities $p_i = (|\delta_i| + 10^{-6})^{0.6}$, caps their mean-normalized values at 2, and renormalizes the resulting critic coefficients to unit minibatch mean. Unlike PER, it uses no priority buffer, nonuniform replay, or importance correction. It therefore matches SABER's intervention point while replacing local replay support with TD error as the allocation signal. Together, the comparisons separate *where* learning effort is reallocated—hindsight selection, replay selection, or critic-loss allocation—from *which signal* drives that allocation. AER, high-replay-ratio HER, and REDQ-HER are retained as secondary scaling references because they additionally change HER usage, update budget, or architecture.

Table 1 summarizes final success, success AUC, and Hit90 across all task–backbone cohorts. Figure 3 complements these aggregate metrics by showing FPP learning dynamics across all three backbones.

Matched HER comparison. SABER achieves higher mean AUC than matched HER in all seven task–backbone cohorts while preserving replay sampling, HER relabeling, Bellman targets, actor optimization, architecture, and UTD. On FPP, mean AUC increases from 0.539 to 0.609 with DDPG, from 0.372 to 0.442 with TD3, and from 0.471 to 0.583 with SAC. Paired 95% confidence intervals exclude zero for TD3 and SAC but include zero for DDPG. The largest gain occurs on DrawerOpen DDPG, where AUC increases from 0.207 to 0.754, final success from 0.390 to 1.000, and Hit90 coverage from 2/5 to 5/5 seeds. Mean AUC also increases under both DDPG and TD3 on DrawerClose. Thus, reallocating critic loss alone can consistently improve the mean learning outcome of an otherwise fixed HER pipeline.

HGR comparison. HGR and SABER address different allocation decisions in HER-based learning: HGR changes which hindsight experiences enter an update, whereas SABER changes the relative critic-fitting contribution of experiences already selected. SABER achieves higher mean AUC on all three FPP backbones and on DrawerOpen DDPG. HGR is slightly higher on DrawerOpen TD3 and higher on both DrawerClose backbones. On DrawerClose, however, HGR's higher AUC does not imply stronger terminal stability: final success is 0.080 versus SABER's 0.280 with DDPG and 0.500 versus 0.590 with TD3. The comparison therefore indicates different task-dependent operating regimes rather than a universal ordering. In our recorded implementations, HGR has lower throughput than SABER in every evaluated cohort; these hardware-specific measurements are reported separately and are not used as a performance claim.

TD-error weighting and PER comparisons. SABER achieves higher mean AUC than TD-error critic-loss weighting in all seven cohorts. This is the closest allocation-level comparison because both methods preserve uniform replay, minibatch membership, Bellman targets, and critic-only application. The result shows that the matched TD-error weighting rule does not reproduce SABER's gains and distinguishes current-policy support from direct TD-error emphasis.

Across all seven cohorts, PER produces a mixed ordering. SABER has higher mean AUC on FPP DDPG, FPP TD3, and both DrawerClose backbones, whereas PER is higher on FPP SAC and both DrawerOpen backbones. DrawerClose TD3

Table 1: Primary post-HER comparisons over paired seeds 1–5. Entries are mean ± sample standard deviation; Hit90 is the median first step reaching 90% success, with reached-seed coverage in parentheses. Repeated *HER+* prefixes are omitted for compactness. SABER denotes our method, and its reported values are shown in bold. FPP SAC uses the exact common 50k–1M evaluation grid.

FetchPickAndPlace (FPP; 1M)

Method	Final	AUC	Hit90
DDPG			
SABER	**0.960 ± .042**	**0.609 ± .038**	**540k (5/5)**
HER	0.940 ± .042	0.539 ± .125	600k (5/5)
HGR	0.540 ± .365	0.338 ± .149	930k (2/5)
TD-error weighting	0.930 ± .104	0.568 ± .069	630k (5/5)
PER	0.780 ± .438	0.460 ± .238	640k (4/5)
TD3			
SABER	**0.970 ± .045**	**0.442 ± .035**	**840k (5/5)**
HER	0.840 ± .188	0.372 ± .032	980k (3/5)
HGR	0.610 ± .198	0.367 ± .034	630k (1/5)
TD-error weighting	0.490 ± .171	0.351 ± .021	630k (1/5)
PER	0.660 ± .204	0.369 ± .034	1.00M (1/5)
SAC			
SABER	**0.990 ± .022**	**0.583 ± .030**	**750k (5/5)**
HER	0.790 ± .288	0.471 ± .079	800k (3/5)
HGR	0.760 ± .251	0.484 ± .071	800k (2/5)
TD-error weighting	0.990 ± .022	0.544 ± .068	800k (5/5)
PER	0.990 ± .022	0.690 ± .046	550k (5/5)

DrawerOpen (2M)

Method	Final	AUC	Hit90
DDPG			
SABER	**1.000 ± .000**	**0.754 ± .044**	**500k (5/5)**
HER	0.390 ± .534	0.207 ± .287	960k (2/5)
HGR	0.900 ± .224	0.688 ± .142	530k (5/5)
TD-error weighting	0.800 ± .447	0.715 ± .090	610k (5/5)
PER	0.990 ± .022	0.825 ± .044	330k (5/5)
TD3			
SABER	**0.590 ± .539**	**0.362 ± .338**	**780k (3/5)**
HER	0.190 ± .425	0.127 ± .283	740k (1/5)
HGR	0.580 ± .531	0.371 ± .343	760k (3/5)
TD-error weighting	0.400 ± .548	0.202 ± .284	1.015M (2/5)
PER	0.600 ± .548	0.406 ± .374	720k (3/5)

DrawerClose (2M)

Method	Final	AUC	Hit90
DDPG			
SABER	**0.280 ± .251**	**0.324 ± .082**	**20k (5/5)**
HER	0.160 ± .182	0.251 ± .030	70k (5/5)
HGR	0.080 ± .091	0.349 ± .184	100k (5/5)
TD-error weighting	0.400 ± .166	0.313 ± .098	130k (5/5)
PER	0.460 ± .363	0.308 ± .049	60k (5/5)
TD3			
SABER	**0.590 ± .539**	**0.549 ± .422**	**80k (5/5)**
HER	0.350 ± .480	0.329 ± .348	70k (5/5)
HGR	0.500 ± .457	0.602 ± .305	80k (5/5)
TD-error weighting	0.200 ± .447	0.369 ± .275	30k (5/5)
PER	0.600 ± .548	0.524 ± .379	120k (5/5)

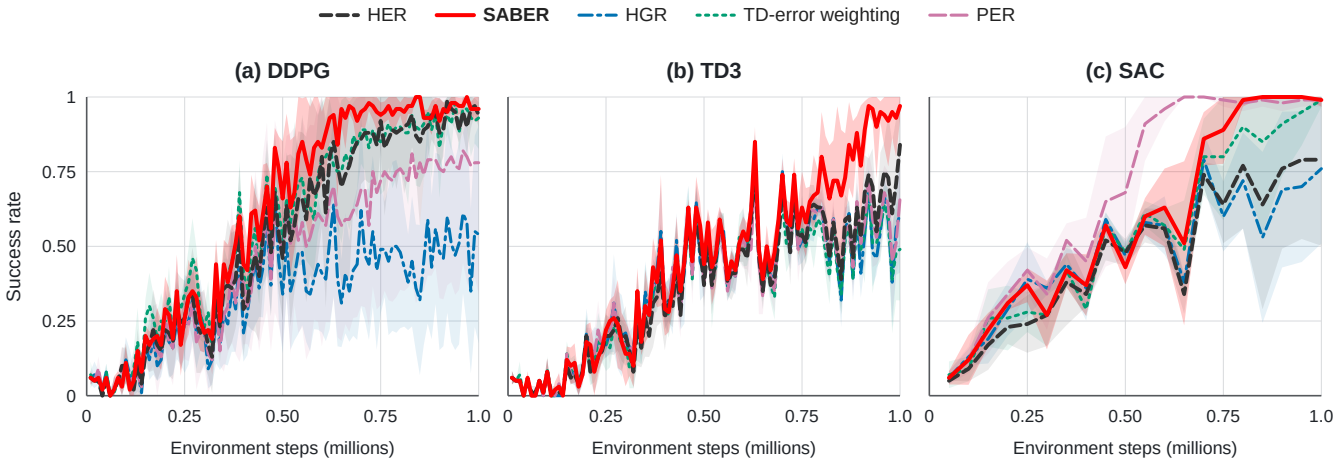


Figure 3: FetchPickAndPlace learning curves for the primary comparisons across DDPG, TD3, and SAC. Lines show mean deterministic evaluation success over paired seeds 1–5, and shaded regions show sample standard deviation. DDPG and TD3 use the exact 10k evaluation grid, while SAC uses the exact shared 50k grid. No smoothing or interpolation is applied; corresponding AUC, final-success, and Hit90 values are reported in Table 1.

also exposes a metric trade-off: SABER attains higher AUC (0.549 versus 0.524) and an earlier median Hit90 (80k versus 120k), while PER has marginally higher mean final success (0.600 versus 0.590). PER changes the replay distribution and applies importance correction, so it is a broader replay-selection intervention rather than a matched loss-allocation control. Neither replay prioritization nor critic-loss allocation therefore uniformly dominates across tasks, backbones, and metrics.

Taken together, these comparisons place SABER within a broader family of HER-based learning improvements while isolating its distinct post-relabeling intervention point. SABER raises mean AUC over matched HER and TD-error critic-loss weighting in all seven cohorts and remains competitive with HGR and PER. Experience selection is therefore not the only consequential design decision in HER actor–critic training: critic-loss allocation within an already sampled and relabeled minibatch is a distinct and empirically consequential design axis.

Table 2: Support-signal diagnostics. Parentheses give the number of seeds. Support-positive rates are means ± sample standard deviations; ratios compare support-positive with support-negative means.

Cohort (n)	Support rate	Pre-TD ratio	1-step $\Delta\lvert\delta\rvert$
FPP DDPG (5)	0.367 ± 0.011	$1.42\times$	$2.39\times$
FPP TD3 (5)	0.219 ± 0.009	$1.62\times$	$3.30\times$
FPP SAC (5)	0.197 ± 0.013	$1.74\times$	$3.94\times$
DrawerOpen DDPG (10)	0.429 ± 0.051	$1.17\times$	$2.10\times$

4.3 Diagnostic Instrumentation

Diagnostic logging adds no gradient terms and does not alter replay sampling, training objectives, or the parameter-update order. For FPP, we record one full minibatch every 10k environment steps for seeds 1–5 of DDPG, TD3, and SAC, yielding 500 diagnostic batches per backbone and 1,500 in total. DrawerOpen DDPG uses a separate ten-seed diagnostic cohort. Snapshot-level quantities are first averaged within each seed, and seeds are treated as the independent analysis units.

Support activation. We first measure how often SABER's support condition activates during training. The support-positive rate is the fraction of logged samples for which $\psi_i = 1$. It is 0.367 ± 0.011, 0.219 ± 0.009, and 0.197 ± 0.013 for FPP DDPG, TD3, and SAC, respectively, and 0.429 ± 0.051 for DrawerOpen DDPG. Although activation varies across tasks and backbones, the indicator consistently identifies a nontrivial subset of each minibatch rather than degenerating to an almost-always or almost-never signal.

TD-error enrichment. We next relate support to the pre-update absolute Bellman residual $|\delta_i^{\mathrm{pre}}|$. For FPP DDPG, TD3, and SAC, Pearson correlations with the binary support indicator are weak at 0.116, 0.128, and 0.143. Nevertheless, support-positive rates within the top TD-error decile are enriched by $1.409\times$, $1.670\times$, and $1.828\times$ over their corresponding base rates. On DrawerOpen, mean pre-update absolute residuals are 0.291 for support-positive and 0.249 for support-negative samples, a $1.17\times$ ratio whose direction holds in all ten seeds. Support therefore concentrates in high-error regions without reducing to a TD-error ranking.

One-update residual reduction. To test whether support-conditioned weights affect the intended critic update, we hold the Bellman targets fixed and measure $|\delta_i^{\mathrm{pre}}| - |\delta_i^{\mathrm{post}}|$ on the same minibatch after one critic step. Mean reductions for support-positive/negative samples are $0.0192/0.0080$, $0.0213/0.0065$, and $0.0223/0.0057$ for FPP DDPG, TD3, and SAC, corresponding to ratios of $2.39\times$, $3.30\times$, and $3.94\times$. The positive-sample reduction is larger in all 15 FPP backbone–seed runs. DrawerOpen similarly gives $0.00754/0.00359$, or $2.10\times$, with the same direction in all ten seeds. These results verify that SABER translates its support signal into the intended redistribution of immediate critic fitting; the independent contribution of exact sample assignment is evaluated in the subsequent ablations.

Phase-conditioned allocation. Finally, we examine where support activates along DrawerOpen task progression. Using task-defined phases conditioned on the relabeled training goal, support-positive rates are 0.737, 0.656, 0.641, and 0.326 for approach, contact, opening, and open, respectively; opening is aggregated over the nine seeds in which that phase is observed. Although open accounts for 73.8% of logged samples, it has the lowest support-positive rate. SABER therefore activates more frequently during approach and drawer-interaction phases than in the most prevalent, already-open phase. Full phase counts, batch fractions, and seed-level results are reported in the supplement.

4.4 Mechanism Ablations

The primary comparisons establish SABER's performance effect but do not identify whether it arises from the action used to query support, the pairing between that action and the sampled context, or the sample-wise placement of high critic weights. We therefore evaluate four controls with DDPG on FPP, DrawerOpen, and DrawerClose using paired seeds 1–5. Unless stated otherwise, each control retains Main SABER's task-specific training budget, HER and replay procedures, support hyperparameters, critic-only scope, UTD ratio, and evaluation protocol, without variant-specific retuning. Table 3 reports paired Main-minus-control AUC differences; positive values favor Main SABER.

Replay-Action Query. This control tests whether querying support with the current-policy action is more useful for learning than querying with the replay action. We replace a_i^π with a_i^r only in the support-membership query, while retaining the sample context, population thresholds, weight computation, Bellman regression at the replay action, and the unweighted actor objective. The sampled transition is not removed from its local replay pool, so its replay action can support itself when it appears within the bounded scan. Main SABER achieves higher mean AUC by $+0.011$, $+0.436$, and $+0.049$ on FPP, DrawerOpen, and DrawerClose, respectively. The DrawerOpen confidence interval excludes zero, providing the clearest task-level evidence that using the current-policy action as the support query can materially affect learning.

Shuffled-Policy Query. This control examines whether SABER benefits from pairing each state–goal sample with the current-policy action computed for that sample. We preserve the complete multiset of current-policy actions within the minibatch but apply a fixed-point-free permutation so that every action is paired with a different sample's unchanged context. The shuffled action is used only to query support; the resulting weight remains attached to the original sample's replay-action residual. Main SABER achieves higher mean AUC by $+0.043$, $+0.105$, and $+0.033$ on FPP, DrawerOpen, and DrawerClose, respectively, although all three confidence intervals include zero. The consistent direction suggests that sample–query alignment contributes to SABER's performance. Replay-Action Query and Shuffled-Policy Query can also alter the support-positive count; they therefore measure the overall effects of query identity and

Table 3: Paired Main-minus-control normalized success AUC differences with 95% paired-bootstrap confidence intervals, using DDPG seeds 1–5. Positive values favor Main SABER.

Task	Replay-Action Query	Shuffled-Policy Query	Random-Support	Strict Count-Matched
FPP	$+0.011[-0.028, 0.059]$	$+0.043[-0.002, 0.085]$	$+0.056[0.014, 0.101]$	$+0.033[-0.006, 0.076]$
DrawerOpen	$+0.436[0.121, 0.729]$	$+0.105[-0.080, 0.335]$	$+0.047[-0.042, 0.136]$	$+0.149[-0.042, 0.442]$
DrawerClose	$+0.049[-0.006, 0.128]$	$+0.033[-0.063, 0.119]$	$+0.048[-0.004, 0.115]$	$+0.030[-0.033, 0.092]$

pairing, including induced count changes, rather than isolating alignment under a matched count.

Random-Support. The query controls can change the number of samples receiving a high weight. Random-Support separates this count effect from the identities of the selected samples. At each control update, we apply Main SABER's indicator rule to that control run's own minibatch and replay state, obtaining a counterfactual Main mask M and positive count $k = \sum_i M_i$. We then draw exactly k minibatch positions uniformly without replacement and assign them the high raw weight. Random-Support therefore preserves Main's per-update positive count and raw and normalized weight distributions while removing sample-level context eligibility and action-bin membership alignment from the high-weight locations. Main SABER achieves higher mean AUC on all three tasks, and its $+0.056$ advantage on FPP has a confidence interval that excludes zero. This result indicates that SABER's gains cannot be explained solely by assigning larger weights to a matched number of arbitrary residuals. Because k is still obtained from Main's support computation, Random-Support is a count-matched control rather than a support-free random baseline.

Strict Context-Eligible Count-Matched. Random-Support can assign high weights to samples whose local replay contexts are not sufficiently populated. We therefore construct a stricter control that also matches context eligibility. At each update, we apply Main SABER's rule to the control run's own minibatch and replay state to obtain the counterfactual Main mask and its positive count k. We then form an eligible set E containing samples that satisfy Main SABER's local-context population conditions and draw exactly k samples uniformly without replacement from E. This control matches Main in positive count, raw and normalized weight distributions, and eligibility domain. By construction, its only intended remaining algorithmic difference from Main is whether the high-weight sample locations are selected by current-policy action-bin membership. Main SABER achieves higher mean AUC by $+0.033$, $+0.149$, and $+0.030$ on FPP, DrawerOpen, and DrawerClose, respectively, but all three confidence intervals include zero. The results are consistent with a contribution from membership-aligned weight assignment, but do not independently establish exact support membership as the unique causal mechanism.

5 Results

5.1 Cross-Backbone Repeatability

SABER produces a repeatable cross-backbone improvement under matched one-update budgets.

SABER raises mean FPP AUC from 0.539 to 0.609 on DDPG, 0.372 to 0.442 on TD3, and 0.471 to 0.583 on SAC. The paired AUC intervals exclude zero for TD3 and SAC, and all three backbones improve in mean final success and Hit90 coverage. This demonstrates cross-backbone compatibility rather than a single-backbone anomaly.

Ten-seed TD3 confirmation. A frozen paired extension on seeds 6–10 gives ten matched TD3 pairs on the exact 10k–1M grid. HER versus SABER reaches AUC 0.383 ± 0.041 versus 0.429 ± 0.058, with paired delta $+0.0467[0.0085, 0.0783]$; 8/10 seed deltas are positive and every leave-one-out mean remains positive. The extension corroborates the five-seed result while preserving its finite-seed boundary: DDPG supplies mean-improvement rather than interval-closed evidence, and neither result implies improvement on every seed.

5.2 Policy-Aligned Querying Is Substantive

The support query is not interchangeable with replay-action querying or sample-misaligned policy querying.

The main current-policy query exceeds replay-query and shuffled-policy on every paired seed. Replay-query has a higher support-positive rate than Main (0.426 versus 0.219) yet lower AUC, while shuffling preserves the policy-action marginal distribution but removes sample alignment. Thus query identity and sample alignment matter beyond merely producing more support-positive weights.

Count-matched assignment. Each control update recomputes E, M, k and samples $Z \subseteq E$, $|Z| = k$, without using membership locations; instrumented summaries record no count or weight-distribution violations. Main versus control AUC is 0.4424 ± 0.0350 versus 0.3908 ± 0.0700, with paired difference $+0.0516[-0.0165, 0.0992]$, 4/5 positive seeds, and exact $p = 0.25$. This removes the count confound and directionally favors membership alignment, but does not confirm its independent contribution.

5.3 A Favorable Gradient-Update Trade-Off

On DDPG and TD3, SABER reaches AUC comparable to $4\times$ replay-ratio HER with one quarter of the gradient-update budget.

For TD3, comparable AUC is accompanied by substantially higher final success (0.970 versus 0.610) and Hit90 coverage (5/5 versus 1/5). SABER therefore offers a complementary one-update allocation strategy rather than relying

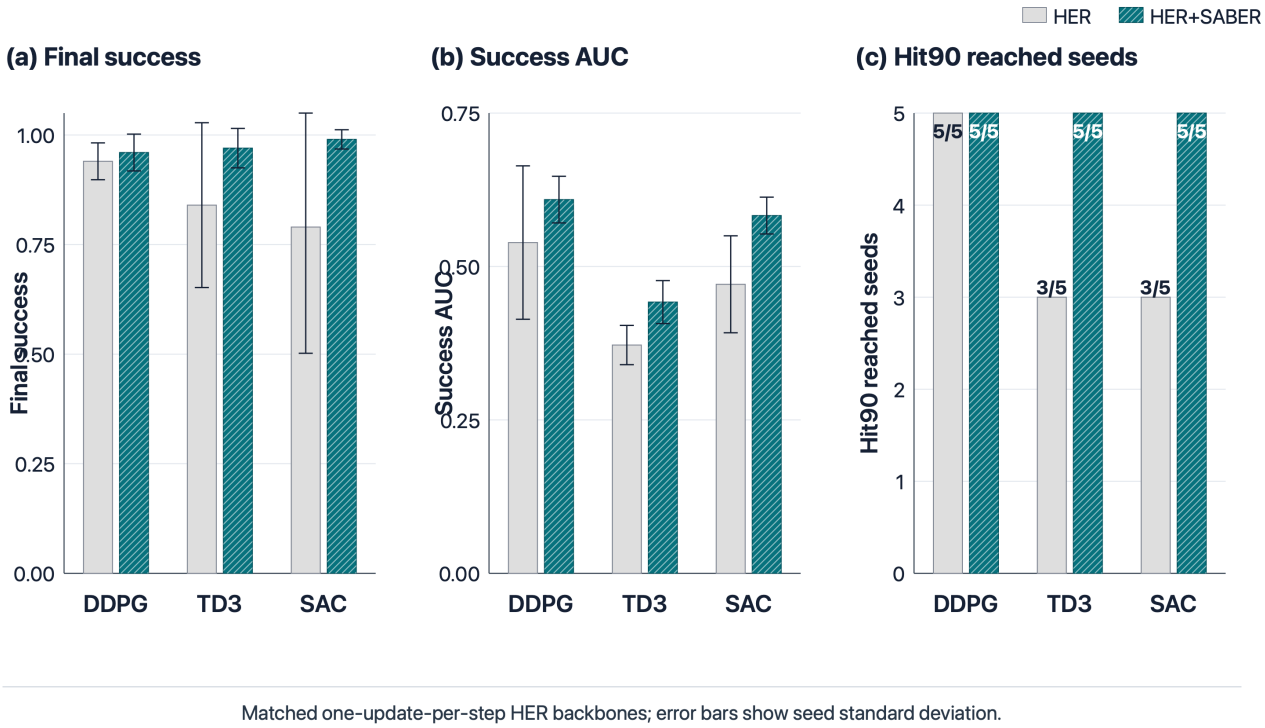


Figure 4: FetchPickAndPlace evidence across matched one-update-per-step HER backbones. Bars and error bars show the seed mean and standard deviation. Exact paired 95% SABER–HER intervals are reported in Table 4; the AUC interval includes zero for DDPG and excludes zero for TD3/SAC.

Table 4: Matched-backbone comparison: FPP main results and matched HGR reference at 1M steps. SAC AUC and Hit90 use the exact shared 50k–1M grid. SABER improves means across all backbones; paired AUC CIs are clearer for TD3/SAC than DDPG.

Backbone	Method	Final	AUC	Hit90	Steps/sec
DDPG	HER	0.940 ± 0.042	0.539 ± 0.125	600k (5/5)	65.03
DDPG	**HER+SABER (Ours)**	$\mathbf{0.960 \pm 0.042}$	$\mathbf{0.609 \pm 0.038}$	**540k (5/5)**	**41.72**
DDPG	HGR (matched)	0.540 ± 0.365	0.338 ± 0.149	930k (2/5)	16.93
TD3	HER	0.840 ± 0.188	0.372 ± 0.032	980k (3/5)	65.33
TD3	**HER+SABER (Ours)**	$\mathbf{0.970 \pm 0.045}$	$\mathbf{0.442 \pm 0.035}$	**840k (5/5)**	**41.25**
SAC	HER	0.790 ± 0.288	0.471 ± 0.079	800k (3/5)	38.93
SAC	**HER+SABER (Ours)**	$\mathbf{0.990 \pm 0.022}$	$\mathbf{0.583 \pm 0.030}$	**750k (5/5)**	**29.10**
DDPG	Δ SABER–HER	$+0.020[-0.040, 0.070]$	$+0.070[-0.016, 0.193]$	–	–
TD3	Δ SABER–HER	$+0.130[-0.030, 0.310]$	$+0.071[0.032, 0.095]$	–	–
SAC	Δ SABER–HER	$+0.200[-0.020, 0.430]$	$+0.112[0.064, 0.161]$	–	–

on brute-force replay scaling. **Boundary:** this is a gradient-update trade-off, not a wall-clock-efficiency claim; SAC high-RR and REDQ-HER TQB attain higher AUC with larger update or architecture budgets.

5.4 Large-Effect Rescue on DrawerOpen

SABER rescues a failure-prone HER regime on DrawerOpen. It raises final success from 0.390 to 1.000, AUC from 0.207 to 0.754, and Hit90 coverage from 2/5 to 5/5 seeds. This shows that critic-side allocation can have a large practical effect when matched HER suffers from seed-level failures.

Random-support and PER-style controls are also strong, so DrawerOpen establishes intervention-family significance rather than unique structured-support causality. The HGR-style sampler-only row reaches Hit90 in 2/5 seeds; SABER minus HGR-style is $+0.443[0.106, 0.780]$ in AUC, but the row is not full HGR. Scaled REDQ-HER TQB reaches Hit90 earlier (370k versus 500k median), whereas SABER has higher mean AUC and lower variance, 0.754 ± 0.044 versus 0.672 ± 0.314; neither method dominates every seed or metric.

Table 5: FPP TD3 mechanism controls at 1M steps, seeds 1–5. Paired 95% CIs compare Main with each row. The strict control samples $k = |M|$ positions from E on each control update; context-count only is count-unmatched.

Query / control	Final	AUC	Hit90	Main − row AUC [CI]
HER	0.840 ± 0.188	0.372 ± 0.032	980k (3/5)	$+0.071[0.032, 0.095]$
Main SABER (Ours)	$\mathbf{0.970 \pm 0.045}$	$\mathbf{0.442 \pm 0.035}$	**840k (5/5)**	–
Replay action	0.660 ± 0.219	0.368 ± 0.042	920k (1/5)	$+0.075[0.059, 0.092]$
Shuffled policy	0.550 ± 0.226	0.347 ± 0.051	890k (1/5)	$+0.096[0.063, 0.128]$
Context-eligible count-matched	0.910 ± 0.096	0.391 ± 0.070	955k (4/5)	$+0.052[-0.016, 0.099]$
Context-count only	0.800 ± 0.242	0.396 ± 0.090	850k (3/5)	$+0.047[-0.041, 0.122]$

Table 6: Scaling references: FPP SAC/REDQ metrics use the exact shared 50k–1M grid. High-RR and REDQ rows expose update/backbone budget tradeoffs.

Backbone	Method	Updates/step	Final	AUC	Hit90	Runtime h
DDPG	**HER+SABER (Ours)**	**1**	$\mathbf{0.960 \pm 0.042}$	$\mathbf{0.609 \pm 0.038}$	**540k (5/5)**	**6.66**
DDPG	HER high-RR $4\times$	4	0.990 ± 0.022	0.618 ± 0.071	480k (5/5)	16.11
DDPG	HER high-RR $8\times$	8	0.720 ± 0.407	0.443 ± 0.269	620k (3/5)	31.85
TD3	**HER+SABER (Ours)**	**1**	$\mathbf{0.970 \pm 0.045}$	$\mathbf{0.442 \pm 0.035}$	**840k (5/5)**	**6.74**
TD3	HER high-RR $4\times$	4	0.610 ± 0.243	0.449 ± 0.079	630k (1/5)	8.76
SAC	**HER+SABER (Ours)**	**1**	$\mathbf{0.990 \pm 0.022}$	$\mathbf{0.583 \pm 0.030}$	**750k (5/5)**	**9.55**
SAC	HER high-RR $4\times$	4	0.960 ± 0.042	0.768 ± 0.097	450k (5/5)	47.02
REDQ-SAC	REDQ-HER TQB	4	1.000 ± 0.000	0.867 ± 0.052	300k (5/5)	89.52

Table 7: DrawerOpen stress case at 2M steps. DDPG rows use the local matched regime; REDQ-HER TQB is an N=10, M=2, UTD-4 architecture/compute-scaled reference. Hit90 reports median first hit and reached seeds.

Method	Final	AUC	Hit90
HER	0.390 ± 0.534	0.207 ± 0.287	960k (2/5)
HGR-style sampler-only	0.400 ± 0.548	0.311 ± 0.425	450k (2/5)
HER+SABER (Ours)	$\mathbf{1.000 \pm 0.000}$	$\mathbf{0.754 \pm 0.044}$	**500k (5/5)**
Random-support	1.000 ± 0.000	0.706 ± 0.122	510k (5/5)
PER-style	0.800 ± 0.447	0.715 ± 0.090	610k (5/5)
REDQ-HER TQB (scaled)	1.000 ± 0.000	0.672 ± 0.314	370k (5/5)

An independent SABER-only extension reaches Hit90 in 4/5 additional seeds; descriptively pooled over seeds 1–10, SABER reaches 9/10 with final success 0.895 ± 0.315 and AUC 0.652 ± 0.246. Because no matched methods were extended, the original five-seed paired comparisons remain primary. A separate diagnostic rerun reproduces the original five-seed aggregate AUC (0.755 versus 0.754). Across nine successful diagnostic seeds, support-positive samples show $1.17\times$ pre-update TD error and $2.1\times$ same-minibatch residual reduction; failed seed 7 first loses contact exploration and later exhibits support saturation. These in-sample diagnostics characterize allocation and failure behavior rather than causal generalization.

Table 8: Control closure: what the reported controls establish and what remains unresolved.

Evidence	Established	Remaining interpretation
DDPG controls: Random-fixed AUC 0.540 is close to HER 0.539; Random-support AUC 0.604 is close to SABER 0.609.	Fixed-count random weighting alone does not explain the gain.	FPP DDPG does not isolate exact sample-level alignment; count-preserving randomization can regularize.
TD3/SAC random controls stay near or below SABER in AUC.	Random reweighting does not explain all gains across backbones.	TD3/SAC provide the cleanest random-control separation.
High-RR/REDQ rows match or exceed SABER under larger budgets.	SABER offers a distinct one-update allocation strategy.	It does not dominate update or architecture scaling.
FPP HGR (matched) uses pair priorities and episode/pair IS correction but reaches AUC 0.338 and Hit90 in 2/5; SABER reaches 0.609 and 5/5.	Matched goal prioritization does not explain SABER's gain in this regime.	This is not an exact original-paper reproduction or a general HGR ranking.
Diagnostics show weak TD-error correlation, top-error enrichment, and larger immediate correction in TD3/SAC.	SABER is not PER-style largest-error selection.	The evidence supports error allocation, not lower target variance.
Main query AUC 0.442 exceeds replay 0.368 and shuffled 0.347 on all five paired seeds; the context-eligible count-matched control reaches 0.391.	Current-policy identity and sample alignment are substantive, and the strict control removes the positive-count/context-eligibility confound.	Main–control is $+0.052[-0.016, 0.099]$ on 4/5 seeds; membership-specific benefit is directional but not interval-closed.

5.5 Mechanism Characterization and Boundaries

Allocation diagnostics. Instrumented DDPG, TD3, and SAC runs log 500 full diagnostic batches and 64k sample rows per backbone. Support-positive rates are 0.367, 0.219, and 0.197, while Pearson correlations with $|\delta|$ are only 0.116, 0.128, and 0.143. Their top-10% TD-error overlaps are 0.516, 0.360, and 0.342: enriched over each support base rate but far from TD-error equivalence. TD3/SAC support-positive samples also receive larger immediate residual correction after weight normalization. Target variance is higher, not lower, in all three diagnostics, supporting an allocation signal rather than a lower-noise interpretation.

Together, the controls establish a distinct policy-aligned allocation signal on TD3/SAC and characterize where generic reweighting, goal prioritization, or scaling remain competitive. They define the operating regime of the contribution rather than displacing its core matched-budget findings.

6 Discussion

6.1 What SABER Establishes

SABER establishes post-HER critic supervision allocation as a distinct design axis. Holding relabeling, replay, actor optimization, Bellman targets, critic architecture, and update rate fixed provides cleaner effect attribution and a common interface across DDPG, TD3, and SAC. The evidence then localizes the signal: aligned current-policy querying exceeds replay and shuffled-policy queries, cross-backbone and ten-seed results show repeatability, DDPG/TD3 expose a favorable gradient-update trade-off, and DrawerOpen demonstrates that critic-side allocation can rescue a failure-prone HER regime.

6.2 Scope and Limitations

The evidence is scoped in five ways. First, the support predicate is task-specific and uses coarse membership; FetchSlide DDPG decreases from HER final/AUC $0.630/0.324$ to SABER $0.590/0.301$, and DrawerClose remains high variance. Second, query and membership assignment are tested only on FPP TD3. The strict context-eligible count-matched control removes the earlier count confound and favors Main in mean AUC, but its five-seed interval includes zero; a weakly active D8 gate also does not establish a diversity benefit. Third, diagnostics are in-sample allocation measurements, not lower-noise or causal-generalization proofs. Fourth, the current lookup is costly: in a hardware-specific seed-1 profile, TD3 throughput falls from 124.0 to 41.4 steps/s and support/weighting occupies 62.3% of SABER's loop. Fifth, matched FPP HGR is not an exact original-paper reproduction, HGG/MHER/CHER remain untested, and most controls use five seeds.

Statistical scope. Paired deltas use 10,000 seed bootstrap resamples. Exact sign-flip tests for FPP DDPG/TD3/SAC AUC give $p = 0.375/0.125/0.0625$, with positive deltas on 3/5, 4/5, and 5/5 seeds; all leave-one-out means remain positive. With five nonzero pairs, 0.0625 is the minimum attainable two-sided value. The ten-seed TD3 extension contains two negative deltas and exact $p = 0.0527$, while the DrawerOpen extension is SABER-only and unmatched. These checks establish repeatability and outlier stability, not improvement on every seed.

7 Conclusion

SABER establishes post-HER critic supervision allocation as a design axis distinct from relabeling, replay, actor optimization, Bellman targets, architecture, and update rate.

It yields a repeatable cross-backbone FPP signal, corroborated by the paired TD3 ten-seed extension, and aligned current-policy querying outperforms replay/shuffled alternatives. Count matching removes the earlier confound but does not interval-close the incremental membership effect. SABER also offers a DDPG/TD3 gradient-update trade-off and rescues a failure-prone DrawerOpen regime. Generic support representations remain future work.

8 Reproducibility and Anonymity

An anonymized archive provides sanitized configs, exact-grid curves, package-local analyzers/tests, and SHA256 manifests for the matched HGR, TD3 ten-seed, query/count-matched, DrawerOpen, scaling, and runtime evidence. Package commands regenerate compact tables; independent checks cover exact inference, leave-one-out, and table consistency. Public URLs, user namespaces, and raw commit identities are excluded.

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